

What you pay has almost nothing to do with what you get

\$24.00

san marzano tomatoes, basil, buffalo mozzarella (the red margherita)

Pizzeria Toro · Neapolitan pizza

3.10 out of 10

The worst-scoring dish that costs at least twice the one beside it.

\$10.95

Lentil-base bowl with grilled chicken

DICED · US bowl chain

7.11 out of 10

The best-scoring dish under twelve dollars.

\$13.05 more money. -4.01 points.

You can object that a pizza was never going to beat a lentil bowl, and you would be right. So take the harder case: Gifted Hand Cuisine's braised oxtail, a proper cooked dinner at **\$32.79**, scores **4.17**. Of the **30** dishes here that cost less than half as much, **29** beat it. Across all 87 dishes, from 43 cuisines and 87 different restaurants, the relationship between what a dish costs and how good it is for you is **r = +0.09** – which is, in plain English, nothing.

What an extra five dollars actually buys

Not nothing – that is the surprise. Money does buy something. It just does not buy health. Every additional five dollars on a Triangle delivery order brings, on average:

+2.9 g

protein

+28

calories

+73 mg

sodium

+1.0 g

saturated fat

-0.9 g

fibre

Money buys a bigger, richer plate. The good and the bad arrive together, and they cancel.

This is the finding that does not depend on our scoring model at all, and it is the one to trust most. With no model, no weights and no judgement calls – just price against the numbers on the label – price correlates with protein at **+0.33** and with saturated fat at **+0.29**, with sodium at **+0.20** and with fibre at **-0.26**. A more expensive dinner is a larger dinner. Whether that is better for you depends entirely on what the kitchen does, and price does not tell you.

All 87, ranked

Sorted by overall score, so the bars fall by construction – that on its own shows nothing. The price column beside them is on its own scale and is sorted by nothing at all. Read down it.

RANK & DISH

OVERALL SCORE · 0 TO 10

WHAT IT COSTS

2

4

6

8

10

\$10

\$20

\$30

\$40

ORDER THESE 18

strong overall, and nothing collapses on the four criteria that are plain arithmetic

1	Double tuna salad bowl	Poke Bros.	7.9	\$17
2	Oily-cut sashimi selection	M Sushi	7.3	\$31
3	Balık Şiş	Talullas	7.3	\$31
4	Large chicken bowl on salad...	Pokeworks	7.1	\$16
5	Lentil-base bowl with grilled...	DICED	7.1	\$11
6	Sizzling fish with vermicelli a...	Taste Vietna...	7.0	\$18
7	Tuscan Kale Salad with salm...	True Food Ki...	7.0	\$26
8	Tiradito	M Izakaya	7.0	\$20
9	Chicken kebab plate with fatt...	Baba Ghanno.	6.8	\$16
10	Sashimi bowl	Peony Asian Bistro	6.8	\$22
11	Chicken shish kebab with cac...	Bosphorus	6.8	\$16
12	Chicken choila with dal	Kathmandu Kitchen	6.8	\$22
14	Grilled salmon with house sal...	Canastas Ch...	6.7	\$26
16	¼ Chicken w/ White Combo	Alpaca Peruvian...	6.6	\$11
17	Ceviche de tilapia	Mi Perú	6.6	\$24
18	Grilled chicken bowl	Guasaca	6.6	\$11
19	Quarter rotisserie chicken wit...	Luna Rotiss...	6.5	\$19
20	Ceviche Salad	Carmen's Cuban Cafe & Lounge	6.5	\$19

WORTH ORDERING 21

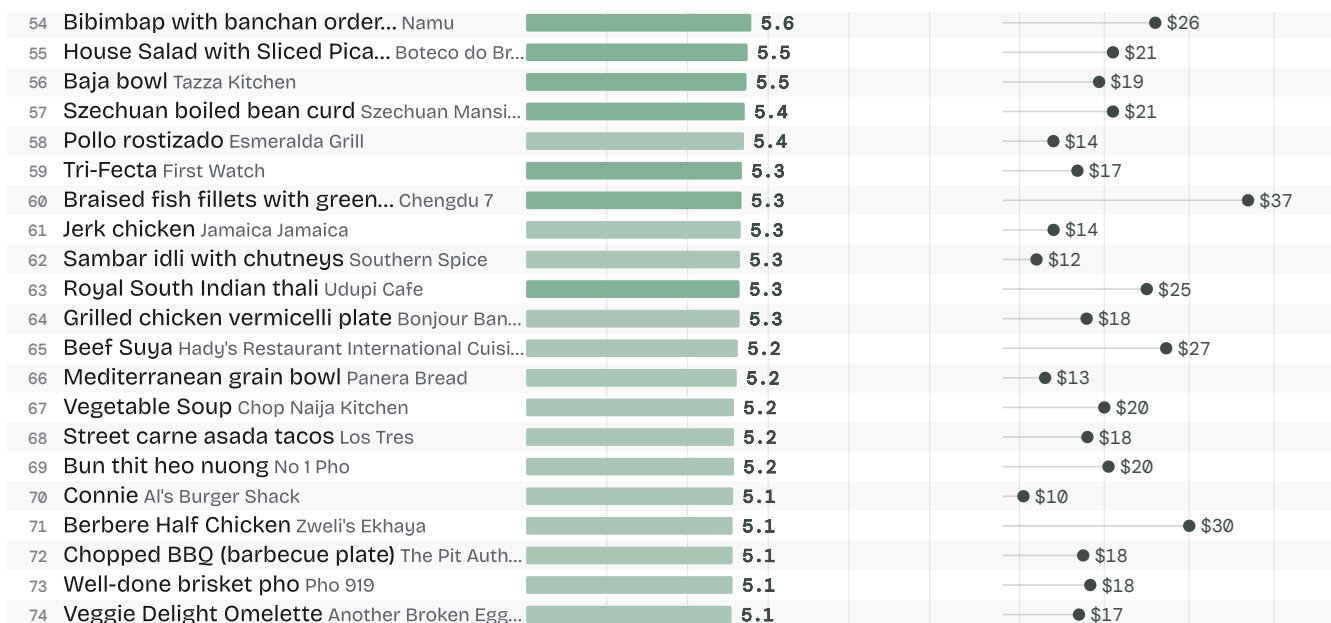
a good plate with one number worth knowing about

13	Nam tok beef with spic...	Thai 54	KID 3.3	6.8	\$31
15	Craft Your Own salad...	Chopt	SUG 3.7	6.6	\$11
21	Chicken Breast (Boneless) ka...	Flame Kabob		6.4	\$25
22	Vegetarian combo with telba...	Abol Ethiopian		6.4	\$17
23	Build Your Own bowl	Mahana Fresh		6.4	\$14
24	Filete de pescado with curtido	El Cuscatleco		6.4	\$16
25	Create Your Own bowl	Happy + Hale		6.4	\$15
26	SuperGreens and lentil bowl...	CAVA		6.4	\$16
27	Vegan vegetable combo	Goorsha		6.3	\$20
28	Build A Bowl	Neomonde		6.3	\$16
29	Pechuga a la Planca	Pupusería Doña Laura		6.3	\$17
30	Create Your Own bowl with a...	Bulkogi		6.3	\$19
31	Build A Bowl, large	Clean Eat		6.3	\$17
32	Tandoori fish tikka with raita...	Urban Turban		6.2	\$27
33	SL6. Grilled Nam-Tok Salad	Twisted Noodles		6.2	\$17
34	Chicken salad with pinto bean...	Chipotle		6.1	\$12
35	Hot honey chicken salad	Village Juice & Kitch...		6.1	\$16
36	Steam Fish (large)	Mum's Jamaican Restaurant		6.1	\$28
37	D6. Steamed Shrimp with Mix...	Golden Drag...		6.1	\$12
38	Souvlaki, chicken	Kipos Greek Taverna		6.1	\$22
39	Regular Chicken Platter	The Halal Guys		6.0	\$15

WITH RESERVATIONS 35

edible, unremarkable, or carrying a real cost somewhere

40	Build Your Own bowl with chic...	Farmside Ki...		6.0	\$13
41	Laphet Thoke (Green tea Sala...	Road To My...		6.0	\$15
42	Smoked Turkey (Smokehous...	Sam Jones B...		6.0	\$21
43	Chicken kabob with labneh an...	Sassool		6.0	\$16
44	Curd rice with idli and sambar	Naga's South...		6.0	\$19
45	Seafood soondubu with a kim...	Chosun Ok		6.0	\$18
46	Tandoori mixed grill	Swagat Indian		5.9	\$22
47	Salad-bar build with grilled ch...	Jason's Deli		5.9	\$13
48	Create Your Own bowl	Roots Natural Kitchen		5.9	\$14
49	Chicken kebab plate	Quick Meal Mediterranean		5.9	\$13
50	Chicken kabob plate	Mediterra Grill		5.8	\$16
51	Salmon bento	Shinmai Shokudo		5.7	\$27
52	Smoked Party Wings, 10 pc	Lawrence Barb...		5.7	\$17
53	Miso Glazed Salmon bowl	Sweetgreen		5.7	\$19



Tinting follows the health score. Two dishes score 6.5 or better and are still held out of the top tier by a criterion that is plain arithmetic on the macros; both are flagged in the row with the criterion that did it.

Why we did not just divide calories by dollars

The obvious measure is the one everybody reaches for first, and it fails badly here. Calories per dollar makes a \$9 plate of fried rice the best purchase in the Triangle and a \$17 tuna bowl one of the worst, which inverts the answer. Protein per dollar is better and still wrong: it ranks a sodium-loaded rotisserie combo above a lentil bowl with two-thirds the salt. A star rating from reviews measures whether people enjoyed dinner, which is a real thing to measure and a different one.

So the score here is nine criteria, and the important disclosure is that they are not all the same kind of number. **Six are arithmetic** on the figures a restaurant publishes or that we estimated from the build – sodium, saturated fat, protein density, sugar, plus flavour and value. **Three are judgements** against a written rubric: gut, steady energy, inflammation. We audited our own model and those three are where it is weakest. They

are drawn differently everywhere in this document – outlined rather than solid – so you can always see which half of a score is computed and which half is opinion.

“You only got that answer because of how you weighted it”

It is the right objection, and it is the one that sank Food Compass – a nutrition score that produced a famously counterintuitive result and had not published how much that result depended on its own weights. So here are ours, tested to destruction.

WEIGHTING	R (PRICE, OVERALL)	R (PRICE, HEALTH)	DICED	PIZZERIA TORO
as published	-0.058	+0.048	#5	#87
flavour weighted equal to health	-0.010	+0.048	#5	#87
cost ignored entirely	+0.097	+0.048	#9	#87
health only	+0.048	+0.048	#8	#87
all nine weighted equally	-0.147	+0.058	#2	#87

Then 2,000 random weightings, each of the nine criteria drawn independently between a quarter and double its published weight. On the sixty dishes that form our representative sample the median correlation is **+0.055**; on all 87 it is **+0.095**. Restricted to the four criteria that are plain arithmetic and that our audit did not dispute, it turns slightly negative (**-0.11**).

What does not survive: about one weighting in ten (10.6% of the 2,000) does push the correlation past +0.2, and the most price-favourable weighting we found reaches +0.35. So the claim is not that no weighting can make price look like a guide to health. It is narrower than that, and it is this: the most favourable weighting of these nine criteria still leaves price explaining about a tenth of the variation in how good a dish is for you, and the typical weighting leaves it explaining none.

The eighty-seven, by what they cost

Not sorted by rank. The bands are the argument: each one holds roughly the same spread of health scores as the one before it, and the money goes up regardless. Walk them in order and the finding arrives without a chart.

How to read an entry

Salt **Fat** **Prot** **Sugar**

Solid cells are arithmetic. Each is computed directly from a number on the label – salt from milligrams of sodium, fat from grams of saturated fat – and the raw figure is printed at the foot of every entry so you can check it.

Fibre **Fuel** **Inflam**

Outlined cells are judgements. These three score the dish against a written rubric rather than a measurement. Our own audit found them the weakest part of the model, so they are drawn differently everywhere and never carry a verdict alone.

Taste **Value**

The last two are not health at all. Taste is a rubric score for how good the dish is to eat; value is what it costs against what it delivers. They sit after a gap so they are never mistaken for the seven that precede them.

Every cell runs 0 to 10 and is tinted on the same scale, so a pale cell is a weak one wherever you meet it. The order never changes: after a few entries the strip reads as a shape rather than nine numbers.

under \$12

7 dishes · median health 6.30 · range 4.0 to 7.0 · mean price \$10.95 · 3 best buys

Lentil-base bowl with grilled chicken **BEST BUY**

DICED · US bowl chain

\$10.95 7.1 overall 7.0 health



STRONG on salt (10.0). WEAK on fibre (3.4).

709 kcal · 57 g protein · 144 mg sodium, 6% of a day · 14 g fibre

PART PUBLISHED, PART ESTIMATED

Craft Your Own salad, grilled chicken

Chopt · US bowl chain

\$10.79 6.6 overall 6.5 health



STRONG on saturated fat (10.0). WEAK on sugar (3.7).

415 kcal · 33 g protein · 735 mg sodium, 32% of a day · 12 g fibre

PUBLISHED FIGURES

¼ Chicken w/ White Combo **BEST BUY**

Alpaca Peruvian Charcoal Chicken · Peruvian

\$11.29 6.6 overall 6.5 health



STRONG on protein (10.0). WEAK on inflammation (2.3).

515 kcal · 53 g protein · 1310 mg sodium, 57% of a day · 9 g fibre

ESTIMATED FROM THE BUILD

Grilled chicken bowl **BEST BUY**

Guasaca · Venezuelan

\$11.21 6.6 overall 6.3 health



STRONG on saturated fat (8.7). WEAK on fibre (2.9).

540 kcal · 42 g protein · 1050 mg sodium, 46% of a day · 11 g fibre

ESTIMATED FROM THE BUILD

Sambar idli with chutneys

Southern Spice · South Indian

\$11.99 5.3 overall 5.2 health



STRONG on saturated fat (10.0). WEAK on protein (1.3).

380 kcal · 14 g protein · 980 mg sodium, 43% of a day
· 8 g fibre ESTIMATED FROM THE BUILD

Connie

Al's Burger Shack · Burgers

\$10.45 5.1 overall 4.8 health



STRONG on sugar (8.7). WEAK on inflammation (0.8).

620 kcal · 45 g protein · 1380 mg sodium, 60% of a day
· 2 g fibre ESTIMATED FROM THE BUILD

Aloo Paneer Tikki Chaat

BLR Food Street · Indian street food

\$10.00 4.4 overall 4.0 health



STRONG on saturated fat (7.3). WEAK on protein (1.0).

505 kcal · 15 g protein · 1350 mg sodium, 59% of a day
· 5 g fibre ESTIMATED FROM THE BUILD

\$12 to \$16

21 dishes · median health 5.84 · range 3.5 to 6.7 · mean price \$14.37 · 1 best buys

Chicken kebab plate with fattoush and tzatziki

Baba Ghannouj · Levantine

\$15.99 6.8 overall 6.7 health



STRONG on protein (8.7). WEAK on inflammation (2.9).

560 kcal · 44 g protein · 1200 mg sodium, 52% of a day
· 8 g fibre ESTIMATED FROM THE BUILD

Build Your Own bowl

Mahana Fresh · US bowl chain

\$14.00 6.4 overall 6.3 health



STRONG on saturated fat (8.3). WEAK on fibre (4.0).

560 kcal · 38 g protein · 950 mg sodium, 41% of a day
· 9 g fibre ESTIMATED FROM THE BUILD

Filete de pescado with curtido

El Cuscatleco · Salvadoran

\$15.95 6.4 overall 6.2 health



STRONG on sugar (8.4). WEAK on fibre (2.3).

720 kcal · 42 g protein · 1200 mg sodium, 52% of a day
· 9 g fibre ESTIMATED FROM THE BUILD

Create Your Own bowl

Happy + Hale · US bowl chain

\$14.58 6.4 overall 6.4 health



STRONG on saturated fat (8.6). WEAK on fibre (4.0).

550 kcal · 35 g protein · 850 mg sodium, 37% of a day
· 11 g fibre ESTIMATED FROM THE BUILD

SuperGreens and lentil bowl with grilled steak

CAVA · US bowl chain

\$15.50 6.4 overall 6.2 health



STRONG on steady energy (9.3). WEAK on inflammation (2.9).

775 kcal · 50 g protein · 1295 mg sodium, **56% of a day**
· 27 g fibre PUBLISHED FIGURES

Build A Bowl

Neomonde · Levantine

\$15.99 6.3 overall 6.2 health



STRONG on sugar (8.4). WEAK on fibre (4.0).

580 kcal · 38 g protein · 1050 mg sodium, **46% of a day**
· 10 g fibre ESTIMATED FROM THE BUILD

Chicken salad with pinto beans and guacamole

BEST BUY

Chipotle · US bowl chain

\$12.00 6.1 overall 6.0 health



STRONG on steady energy (9.0). WEAK on fibre (1.7).

575 kcal · 44 g protein · 1055 mg sodium, **46% of a day**
· 17 g fibre PUBLISHED FIGURES

D6. Steamed Shrimp with Mixed Vegetables Diet

Golden Dragon · Chinese-American

\$12.39 6.1 overall 6.2 health



STRONG on saturated fat (10.0). WEAK on sugar (2.6).

438 kcal · 37 g protein · 940 mg sodium, **41% of a day**
· 10 g fibre ESTIMATED FROM THE BUILD

Regular Chicken Platter

The Halal Guys · Halal cart

\$14.75 6.0 overall 6.0 health



STRONG on protein (10.0). WEAK on inflammation (0.9).

400 kcal · 54 g protein · 1028 mg sodium, **45% of a day**
· 4 g fibre PUBLISHED FIGURES

Build Your Own bowl with chicken and quinoa

Farmside Kitchen · US bowl chain

\$13.14 6.0 overall 5.9 health



STRONG on sugar (8.9). WEAK on fibre (2.3).

600 kcal · 35 g protein · 620 mg sodium, **27% of a day**
· 11 g fibre ESTIMATED FROM THE BUILD

Laphet Thoke (Green tea Salad)

Road To Myanmar Asian Cuisine · Burmese

\$14.99 6.0 overall 5.8 health



STRONG on steady energy (8.5). WEAK on salt (1.9).

690 kcal · 31 g protein · 1680 mg sodium, **73% of a day**
· 14 g fibre ESTIMATED FROM THE BUILD

Salad-bar build with grilled chicken

Jason's Deli · US bowl chain

\$12.89 5.9 overall 5.8 health



STRONG on sugar (8.4). WEAK on fibre (3.4).

560 kcal · 40 g protein · 1200 mg sodium, **52% of a day**
· 7 g fibre ESTIMATED FROM THE BUILD

Create Your Own bowl

Roots Natural Kitchen · US bowl chain

\$14.00 5.9 overall 5.7 health



STRONG on saturated fat (8.2). WEAK on fibre (4.0).

580 kcal · 32 g protein · 950 mg sodium, **41% of a day**
· 12 g fibre ESTIMATED FROM THE BUILD

Chicken kebab plate

Quick Meal Mediterranean · Levantine

\$12.99 5.9 overall 5.6 health



STRONG on protein (9.0). WEAK on fibre (1.7).

540 kcal · 44 g protein · 1100 mg sodium, **48% of a day**
· 6 g fibre ESTIMATED FROM THE BUILD

Chicken kabob plate

Mediterra Grill · Levantine

\$15.99 5.8 overall 5.5 health



STRONG on protein (9.2). WEAK on fibre (1.7).

560 kcal · 46 g protein · 1150 mg sodium, **50% of a day**
· 6 g fibre ESTIMATED FROM THE BUILD

Pollo rostizado

Esmeralda Grill · Mexican

\$13.99 5.4 overall 5.1 health



STRONG on sugar (9.5). WEAK on fibre (1.1).

620 kcal · 52 g protein · 1200 mg sodium, **52% of a day**
· 5 g fibre ESTIMATED FROM THE BUILD

Jerk chicken

Jamaica Jamaica · Caribbean

\$14.00 5.3 overall 4.9 health



STRONG on protein (8.3). WEAK on steady energy (2.7).

620 kcal · 46 g protein · 1500 mg sodium, **65% of a day**
· 5 g fibre ESTIMATED FROM THE BUILD

Mediterranean grain bowl

Panera Bread · US bowl chain

\$13.00 5.2 overall 5.1 health



STRONG on saturated fat (8.4). WEAK on protein (2.9).

550 kcal · 24 g protein · 1250 mg sodium, **54% of a day**
· 10 g fibre ESTIMATED FROM THE BUILD

Brown stew chicken

Rese's Caribbean Kitchen · Caribbean

\$14.49 4.7 overall 4.4 health



STRONG on protein (7.1). WEAK on steady energy (2.4).

640 kcal · 42 g protein · 1400 mg sodium, **61% of a day**
· 5 g fibre ESTIMATED FROM THE BUILD

Malibu Poke with salmon

Bul Box · Hawaiian/poke

\$15.89 4.3 overall 4.2 health



STRONG on saturated fat (9.6). WEAK on sugar (0.0).

445 kcal · 23 g protein · 1951 mg sodium, **85% of a day**
· 10 g fibre PART PUBLISHED, PART ESTIMATED

Beef empanadas (two), with sides

Makus Empanadas · Argentine

\$15.25 3.8 overall 3.5 health



STRONG on sugar (9.5). WEAK on fibre (1.7).

905 kcal · 31 g protein · 1560 mg sodium, 68% of a day
· 8 g fibre ESTIMATED FROM THE BUILD

\$16 to \$20

31 dishes · median health 5.61 · range 3.8 to 8.2 · mean price \$17.82

Double tuna salad bowl

Poke Bros. · Hawaiian/poke

\$17.00 7.9 overall 8.2 health



STRONG on salt (10.0). WEAK on fibre (2.9).

542 kcal · 51 g protein · 201 mg sodium, 9% of a day
· 9 g fibre PUBLISHED FIGURES

Large chicken bowl on salad base

Pokeworks · Hawaiian/poke

\$16.00 7.1 overall 7.2 health



STRONG on sugar (10.0). WEAK on fibre (2.9).

400 kcal · 43 g protein · 535 mg sodium, 23% of a day
· 6 g fibre PUBLISHED FIGURES

Sizzling fish with vermicelli and herbs

Taste Vietnamese · Vietnamese

\$17.95 7.0 overall 6.9 health



STRONG on inflammation (9.4). WEAK on salt (4.2).

600 kcal · 40 g protein · 1300 mg sodium, 57% of a day
· 7 g fibre ESTIMATED FROM THE BUILD

Chicken shish kebab with cacik

Bosphorus · Turkish

\$16.50 6.8 overall 6.6 health



STRONG on protein (9.2). WEAK on inflammation (2.3).

580 kcal · 48 g protein · 1150 mg sodium, 50% of a day
· 9 g fibre ESTIMATED FROM THE BUILD

Quarter rotisserie chicken with two salads

Luna Rotisserie · Latin American

\$18.70 6.5 overall 6.6 health



STRONG on saturated fat (9.5). WEAK on fibre (2.9).

420 kcal · 34 g protein · 820 mg sodium, 36% of a day
· 9 g fibre ESTIMATED FROM THE BUILD

Ceviche Salad

Carmen's Cuban Cafe & Lounge · Cuban

\$18.95 6.5 overall 6.8 health



STRONG on saturated fat (9.7). WEAK on fibre (1.7).

310 kcal · 28 g protein · 880 mg sodium, 38% of a day
· 4 g fibre ESTIMATED FROM THE BUILD

Vegetarian combo with telba shiro

Abol Ethiopian · Ethiopian

\$16.99 6.4 overall 6.4 health



STRONG on saturated fat (8.0). WEAK on protein (2.8).

720 kcal · 28 g protein · 1250 mg sodium, **54% of a day**
· 22 g fibre ESTIMATED FROM THE BUILD

Vegan vegetable combo

Goorsha · Ethiopian

\$19.55 6.3 overall 6.4 health



STRONG on saturated fat (9.6). WEAK on inflammation (4.0).

450 kcal · 26 g protein · 850 mg sodium, **37% of a day**
· 12 g fibre ESTIMATED FROM THE BUILD

Pechuga a la Planca

Pupuseria Doña Laura · Salvadoran

\$17.00 6.3 overall 6.4 health



STRONG on protein (10.0). WEAK on fibre (1.5).

425 kcal · 46 g protein · 930 mg sodium, **40% of a day**
· 2 g fibre ESTIMATED FROM THE BUILD

Create Your Own bowl with a kimchi side

Bulkogi · Korean

\$18.60 6.3 overall 6.1 health



STRONG on fibre (9.4). WEAK on salt (1.2).

500 kcal · 35 g protein · 1800 mg sodium, **78% of a day**
· 8 g fibre ESTIMATED FROM THE BUILD

Build A Bowl, large

Clean Eat3 · US bowl chain

\$16.79 6.3 overall 6.4 health



STRONG on saturated fat (9.1). WEAK on fibre (2.9).

520 kcal · 42 g protein · 780 mg sodium, **34% of a day**
· 8 g fibre ESTIMATED FROM THE BUILD

SL6. Grilled Nam-Tok Salad

Twisted Noodles · Thai/Isaan

\$17.00 6.2 overall 6.0 health



STRONG on protein (8.8). WEAK on salt (0.2).

370 kcal · 35 g protein · 1960 mg sodium, **85% of a day**
· 4 g fibre ESTIMATED FROM THE BUILD

Hot honey chicken salad

Village Juice & Kitchen · US bowl chain

\$16.45 6.1 overall 6.0 health



STRONG on saturated fat (8.4). WEAK on fibre (4.0).

540 kcal · 36 g protein · 950 mg sodium, **41% of a day**
· 9 g fibre ESTIMATED FROM THE BUILD

Chicken kabob with labneh and three cold salads

Sassool · Levantine

\$16.37 6.0 overall 5.6 health



STRONG on steady energy (8.0). WEAK on salt (1.8).

850 kcal · 44 g protein · 1700 mg sodium, **74% of a day**
· 3 g fibre ESTIMATED FROM THE BUILD

Curd rice with idli and sambar

Naga's South Indian · South Indian

\$19.00 6.0 overall 6.0 health



STRONG on fibre (10.0). WEAK on protein (1.7).

560 kcal · 20 g protein · 1150 mg sodium, **50% of a day**
· 10 g fibre ESTIMATED FROM THE BUILD

Seafood soondubu with a kimchi side

Chosun Ok · Korean

\$18.39 6.0 overall 5.7 health



STRONG on saturated fat (9.0). WEAK on salt (1.8).

540 kcal · 40 g protein · 1700 mg sodium, **74% of a day**
· 7 g fibre ESTIMATED FROM THE BUILD

Smoked Party Wings, 10 pc

Lawrence Barbecue · North Carolina barbecue

\$17.00 5.7 overall 5.5 health



STRONG on sugar (10.0). WEAK on inflammation (0.6).

447 kcal · 41 g protein · 1250 mg sodium, **54% of a day**
· 1 g fibre ESTIMATED FROM THE BUILD

Miso Glazed Salmon bowl

Sweetgreen · US bowl chain

\$18.75 5.7 overall 5.5 health



STRONG on inflammation (10.0). WEAK on protein (3.5).

880 kcal · 34 g protein · 1092 mg sodium, **47% of a day**
· 12 g fibre PUBLISHED FIGURES

Baja bowl

Tazza Kitchen · US bowl chain

\$19.38 5.5 overall 5.3 health



STRONG on sugar (7.4). WEAK on fibre (4.0).

640 kcal · 36 g protein · 1250 mg sodium, **54% of a day**
· 11 g fibre ESTIMATED FROM THE BUILD

Tri-Fecta

First Watch · US breakfast

\$16.81 5.3 overall 5.3 health



STRONG on saturated fat (8.4). WEAK on fibre (2.9).

540 kcal · 28 g protein · 900 mg sodium, **39% of a day**
· 9 g fibre ESTIMATED FROM THE BUILD

Grilled chicken vermicelli plate

Bonjour Banh Mi · Vietnamese

\$17.90 5.3 overall 5.1 health



STRONG on saturated fat (8.5). WEAK on fibre (3.4).

600 kcal · 35 g protein · 1250 mg sodium, **54% of a day**
· 6 g fibre ESTIMATED FROM THE BUILD

Street carne asada tacos

Los Tres · Mexican

\$17.99 5.2 overall 4.9 health



STRONG on sugar (9.5). WEAK on fibre (1.1).

680 kcal · 46 g protein · 1300 mg sodium, **57% of a day**
· 7 g fibre ESTIMATED FROM THE BUILD

Chopped BBQ (barbecue plate)

The Pit Authentic Barbecue · North Carolina barbecue

\$17.50 5.1 overall 4.9 health



STRONG on steady energy (9.0). WEAK on salt (0.7).

638 kcal · 47 g protein · 1880 mg sodium, **82% of a day**
· 8 g fibre ESTIMATED FROM THE BUILD

Well-done brisket pho

Pho 919 · Vietnamese

\$18.34 5.1 overall 4.8 health



STRONG on saturated fat (8.6). WEAK on salt (1.5).

520 kcal · 36 g protein · 1750 mg sodium, **76% of a day**
· 4 g fibre ESTIMATED FROM THE BUILD

Veggie Delight Omelette

Another Broken Egg Cafe · American breakfast

\$16.99 5.1 overall 5.1 health



STRONG on salt (8.3). WEAK on inflammation (1.8).

550 kcal · 31 g protein · 630 mg sodium, **27% of a day**
· 6 g fibre PUBLISHED FIGURES

Kappa & Meen Curry

Grand Malabar Indian Cuisine · Keralan

\$18.99 4.9 overall 4.8 health



STRONG on sugar (9.2). WEAK on saturated fat (2.1).

700 kcal · 39 g protein · 1300 mg sodium, **57% of a day**
· 8 g fibre ESTIMATED FROM THE BUILD

37. Slice Fish Congee

Dim Sum House · Cantonese

\$19.75 4.9 overall 4.9 health



STRONG on sugar (9.5). WEAK on salt (1.3).

605 kcal · 34 g protein · 1780 mg sodium, **77% of a day**
· 5 g fibre ESTIMATED FROM THE BUILD

Eastern NC Style BBQ Sandwich

The Fiction Kitchen · Vegan Southern

\$17.00 4.9 overall 4.6 health



STRONG on saturated fat (7.8). WEAK on salt (1.3).

680 kcal · 42 g protein · 1780 mg sodium, **77% of a day**
· 5 g fibre ESTIMATED FROM THE BUILD

Baked Chicken Wings Combo with 2 Sides

Let's Eat Soul Food · Southern and soul food

\$18.11 4.8 overall 4.7 health



STRONG on protein (8.8). WEAK on salt (0.0).

688 kcal · 54 g protein · 2120 mg sodium, **92% of a day**
· 7 g fibre ESTIMATED FROM THE BUILD

Beef kobidah

Afghan Kebab · Afghan

\$19.79 4.2 overall 3.8 health



STRONG on sugar (8.4). WEAK on fibre (1.7).

780 kcal · 44 g protein · 1450 mg sodium, **63% of a day**
· 6 g fibre ESTIMATED FROM THE BUILD

Manti, four pieces

Silk Road Uzbek · Uzbek

\$16.99 4.0 overall 3.8 health



STRONG on sugar (8.9). WEAK on fibre (0.6).

560 kcal · 28 g protein · 1100 mg sodium, 48% of a day
· 4 g fibre ESTIMATED FROM THE BUILD

\$20 and up

28 dishes · median health 5.87 · range 2.6 to 7.9 · mean price \$25.54

Every dish in this band is beaten on health by something cheaper on this list.

Oily-cut sashimi selection

M Sushi · Japanese

\$31.20 7.3 overall 7.9 health



STRONG on protein (10.0). WEAK on fibre (4.5).

430 kcal · 46 g protein · 620 mg sodium, 27% of a day
· 4 g fibre ESTIMATED FROM THE BUILD

Balık Şiş

Talullas · Turkish

\$31.00 7.3 overall 7.6 health



STRONG on protein (10.0). WEAK on fibre (5.6).

578 kcal · 54 g protein · 845 mg sodium, 37% of a day
· 2 g fibre ESTIMATED FROM THE BUILD

Tuscan Kale Salad with salmon, dressing declined

True Food Kitchen · US bowl chain

\$26.00 7.0 overall 7.5 health



STRONG on salt (10.0). WEAK on fibre (1.1).

380 kcal · 36 g protein · 330 mg sodium, 14% of a day
· 4 g fibre PUBLISHED FIGURES

Tiradito

M Izakaya · Japanese

\$20.40 7.0 overall 7.2 health



STRONG on saturated fat (10.0). WEAK on fibre (1.1).

320 kcal · 30 g protein · 750 mg sodium, 33% of a day
· 3 g fibre ESTIMATED FROM THE BUILD

Sashimi bowl

Peony Asian Bistro · Japanese

\$22.00 6.8 overall 7.1 health



STRONG on saturated fat (10.0). WEAK on fibre (1.7).

420 kcal · 40 g protein · 800 mg sodium, 35% of a day
· 4 g fibre ESTIMATED FROM THE BUILD

Chicken choila with dal

Kathmandu Kitchen · Nepali

\$21.99 6.8 overall 6.8 health



STRONG on protein (9.7). WEAK on fibre (2.3).

460 kcal · 42 g protein · 1100 mg sodium, 48% of a day
· 7 g fibre ESTIMATED FROM THE BUILD

Nam tok beef with spicy papaya salad

Thai 54 · Thai/Isaan

\$30.90 6.8 overall 6.9 health



STRONG on protein (9.6). WEAK on salt (3.3).

470 kcal · 42 g protein · 1450 mg sodium, 63% of a day
· 8 g fibre ESTIMATED FROM THE BUILD

Grilled salmon with house salad and green beans

Canastas Chicken · Peruvian

\$25.50 6.7 overall 6.8 health



STRONG on sugar (9.5). WEAK on fibre (1.7).

560 kcal · 45 g protein · 1150 mg sodium, 50% of a day
· 6 g fibre ESTIMATED FROM THE BUILD

Ceviche de tilapia

Mi Perú · Peruvian

\$24.22 6.6 overall 6.8 health



STRONG on saturated fat (10.0). WEAK on fibre (2.3).

420 kcal · 38 g protein · 1100 mg sodium, 48% of a day
· 6 g fibre ESTIMATED FROM THE BUILD

Chicken Breast (Boneless) kabob

Flame Kabob · Persian

\$24.98 6.4 overall 6.5 health



STRONG on protein (10.0). WEAK on inflammation (2.6).

524 kcal · 56 g protein · 1055 mg sodium, 46% of a day
· 4 g fibre ESTIMATED FROM THE BUILD

Tandoori fish tikka with raita and vegetable jalfrezi

Urban Turban · North Indian

\$27.00 6.2 overall 6.2 health



STRONG on protein (8.6). WEAK on salt (2.4).

650 kcal · 50 g protein · 1600 mg sodium, 70% of a day
· 8 g fibre ESTIMATED FROM THE BUILD

Steam Fish (large)

Mum's Jamaican Restaurant · Jamaican

\$28.48 6.1 overall 6.3 health



STRONG on protein (10.0). WEAK on inflammation (2.8).

545 kcal · 63 g protein · 1250 mg sodium, 54% of a day
· 8 g fibre ESTIMATED FROM THE BUILD

Souvlaki, chicken

Kipos Greek Taverna · Greek

\$22.00 6.1 overall 5.9 health



STRONG on protein (8.6). WEAK on inflammation (2.3).

655 kcal · 50 g protein · 1100 mg sodium, **48% of a day**
· 5 g fibre ESTIMATED FROM THE BUILD

Smoked Turkey (Smokehouse Plate)

Sam Jones BBQ · North Carolina barbecue

\$20.90 6.0 overall 6.0 health



STRONG on protein (10.0). WEAK on salt (0.0).

462 kcal · 55 g protein · 2100 mg sodium, **91% of a day**
· 6 g fibre ESTIMATED FROM THE BUILD

Tandoori mixed grill

Swagat Indian · North Indian

\$22.00 5.9 overall 5.8 health



STRONG on protein (9.0). WEAK on inflammation (1.7).

620 kcal · 50 g protein · 1500 mg sodium, **65% of a day**
· 5 g fibre ESTIMATED FROM THE BUILD

Salmon bento

Shinmai Shokudo · Japanese

\$27.00 5.7 overall 5.7 health



STRONG on inflammation (8.3). WEAK on steady energy (2.4).

680 kcal · 40 g protein · 1350 mg sodium, **59% of a day**
· 6 g fibre ESTIMATED FROM THE BUILD

Bibimbap with banchan ordered separately

Namu · Korean

\$26.00 5.6 overall 5.6 health



STRONG on fibre (10.0). WEAK on steady energy (2.8).

640 kcal · 34 g protein · 1500 mg sodium, **65% of a day**
· 9 g fibre ESTIMATED FROM THE BUILD

House Salad with Sliced Picanha

Boteco do Brazil · Brazilian

\$21.00 5.5 overall 5.4 health



STRONG on protein (8.5). WEAK on inflammation (2.4).

580 kcal · 44 g protein · 1065 mg sodium, **46% of a day**
· 7 g fibre ESTIMATED FROM THE BUILD

Szechuan boiled bean curd

Szechuan Mansion Hotpot · Sichuan

\$21.00 5.4 overall 5.4 health



STRONG on saturated fat (8.8). WEAK on salt (1.2).

480 kcal · 30 g protein · 1800 mg sodium, **78% of a day**
· 7 g fibre ESTIMATED FROM THE BUILD

Braised fish fillets with green Sichuan peppercorn

Chengdu 7 · Sichuan

\$36.95 5.3 overall 5.4 health



STRONG on sugar (8.9). WEAK on salt (0.6).

950 kcal · 48 g protein · 1900 mg sodium, **83% of a day**
· 6 g fibre ESTIMATED FROM THE BUILD

Royal South Indian thali

Udupi Cafe · South Indian

\$24.99 5.3 overall 5.3 health



STRONG on fibre (10.0). WEAK on protein (1.7).

750 kcal · 24 g protein · 1500 mg sodium, **65% of a day**
· 14 g fibre ESTIMATED FROM THE BUILD

Beef Suya

Hady's Restaurant International Cuisine · West African

\$27.29 5.2 overall 5.2 health



STRONG on protein (9.1). WEAK on salt (2.3).

815 kcal · 66 g protein · 1620 mg sodium, **70% of a day**
· 8 g fibre ESTIMATED FROM THE BUILD

Vegetable Soup

Chop Naija Kitchen · Nigerian

\$20.00 5.2 overall 5.1 health



STRONG on steady energy (9.0). WEAK on salt (1.6).

680 kcal · 51 g protein · 1740 mg sodium, **76% of a day**
· 7 g fibre ESTIMATED FROM THE BUILD

Bun thit heo nuong

No 1 Pho · Vietnamese

\$20.50 5.2 overall 4.8 health



STRONG on saturated fat (6.8). WEAK on salt (3.3).

640 kcal · 38 g protein · 1450 mg sodium, **63% of a day**
· 6 g fibre ESTIMATED FROM THE BUILD

Berberé Half Chicken

Zweli's Ekhaya · Southern African

\$30.00 5.1 overall 5.2 health



STRONG on protein (8.5). WEAK on inflammation (2.5).

785 kcal · 59 g protein · 1410 mg sodium, **61% of a day**
· 4 g fibre ESTIMATED FROM THE BUILD

Carne asada plate

MI CANCUN · Mexican

\$24.99 4.5 overall 4.2 health



STRONG on sugar (8.4). WEAK on fibre (2.3).

780 kcal · 50 g protein · 1600 mg sodium, **70% of a day**
· 9 g fibre ESTIMATED FROM THE BUILD

Braised oxtail

Gifted Hand Cuisine · Caribbean

\$32.79 4.2 overall 4.1 health



STRONG on sugar (8.4). WEAK on saturated fat (1.4).

780 kcal · 52 g protein · 1500 mg sodium, **65% of a day**
· 6 g fibre ESTIMATED FROM THE BUILD

san marzano tomatoes, basil, buffalo mozzarella (the red margherita)

Pizzeria Toro · Neapolitan pizza

\$24.00 3.1 overall 2.6 health



STRONG on sugar (8.7). WEAK on salt (0.6).

965 kcal · 36 g protein · 1900 mg sodium, **83% of a day**
· 4 g fibre ESTIMATED FROM THE BUILD

The short lists

The best buys

Under \$13.00 delivered, and health at 6.0 or above.

Six of the 11 dishes under the cap qualify.

\$10.95	Lentil-base bowl with grilled chicken DICED	7.0
\$11.29	¼ Chicken w/ White Combo Alpaca Peruvian Charcoal Chicken	6.5
\$11.21	Grilled chicken bowl Guasaca	6.3
\$12.00	Chicken salad with pinto beans and guacamole Chipotle	6.0

Nothing on this list beats these on both price and health

The efficient frontier: 6 dishes of 87. Every one of the 45 dishes over \$17 is beaten by something cheaper.

\$10.00	Aloo Paneer Tikki Chaat BLR Food Street	4.0
\$10.45	Connie Al's Burger Shack	4.8
\$10.79	Craft Your Own salad, grilled chicken Chopt	6.5
\$10.95	Lentil-base bowl with grilled chicken DICED	7.0
\$16.00	Large chicken bowl on salad base Pokeworks	7.2
\$17.00	Double tuna salad bowl Poke Bros.	8.2

Five dinners

Ordering the five best-value dishes for a working week costs **\$56.63** and averages **6.52** on health.

Ordering the five highest-scoring dishes instead costs **\$106.15** and averages **7.58**. That is **\$49.52** a week – about \$2,575.04 a year – for **+1.06** points. At the very top of the market money does buy something. Across the middle, where almost every order actually happens, it does not.

\$10.95	Lentil-base bowl with grilled chicken DICED	7.0
\$10.79	Craft Your Own salad, grilled chicken Chopt	6.5
\$11.29	¼ Chicken w/ White Combo Alpaca Peruvian Charcoal Chicken	6.5
\$11.21	Grilled chicken bowl Guasaca	6.3
\$12.39	D6. Steamed Shrimp with Mixed Vegetables Diet Golden Dragon	6.2

How to argue with this

Where the numbers come from. 9 of the 87 dishes carry figures the restaurant publishes itself; 2 are part published and part estimated; the rest are estimated from the stated build using USDA reference values. Every entry says which it is, and no estimated figure is ever presented as a measured one. The published entries share a striking property: all of them are assembled bowls or raw fish. Not one heat-cooked dish in the set has published nutrition data, which is why the gap between published and estimated dishes is a fact about who publishes, not about our estimates.

Where it is weakest. Three of the nine criteria are rubric judgements rather than arithmetic, and our own audit found them the least defensible part of the model. Prices are what DoorDash showed, which moves, and excludes fees, tips and promotions. Portion sizes for estimated dishes are the largest source of error. The score is not a health claim about you; it is a comparison between these 87 dishes.

What changed since the first edition. Thirteen dishes were re-scored against figures their restaurants publish. Eleven of the thirteen got *worse* – mean -0.55 – which is the direction you would expect if estimates flatter food, and a reason to read the estimated entries with more suspicion than the published ones.

Eighty-seven dishes from 87 restaurants across 43 cuisines in Durham, Raleigh, Chapel Hill and Cary. Prices and menus as listed on DoorDash. Every figure in this document is computed from the dataset, not typed by hand.